

project.org

QUICK TEACHING GUIDE

In Their Hands

Coins of the New Testament · Everything you need to plan a visit or a virtual visit. PreK–8

James Tissot (1836–1902), Brooklyn Museum

CASES 6 · 7 · 8 | ELEVEN COINS | EIGHT AUTHENTIC · THREE REPLICAS | PREK–8

EXHIBITION OVERVIEW

Eleven coins, three cases

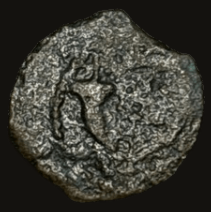
Every coin in this exhibition was made, spent and held during the years of the New Testament. They follow the story in three display cases. **Case 6, The World of Jesus,** holds the coins of the rulers at his birth. **Case 7, Ministry and Passion,** holds the coins of his teaching and his trial. **Case 8, The Early Church,** holds the coins of the rulers the apostles stood before. Eight of the coins are genuine. Three — the Tribute Penny, the Shekel of Tyre and the coin of Herod Antipas — are museum-quality replicas, because original examples are of exceptional rarity.

The core message: the world the Gospels describe was a real world. The coins do not prove the faith — the exhibition says plainly that faith is not proved by archaeology — but its rulers, its taxes and its money can be held in the hand.

CASE 6 · THE WORLD OF JESUS



Augustus Caesar · Luke 2:1

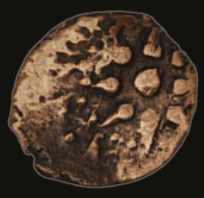


Herod the Great · Matthew 2:13



Aretas IV · Mark 6:17–18

CASE 7 · MINISTRY AND PASSION



The Widow's Mite · Mark 12:41–44



The Tribute Penny · Matthew 22:21 · REPLICA



Shekel of Tyre · Matthew 26:15 · REPLICA



Pontius Pilate · Matthew 27:24



Herod Antipas · Luke 23:9 · REPLICA

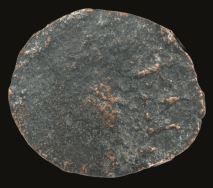
CASE 8 · THE EARLY CHURCH



Herod Agrippa I · Acts 12:2–3



Emperor Claudius · Acts 18:2



Porcius Festus · Acts 25:12

AROUND THE CASES

Four more ways in

- **The Gospel Timeline** — the eleven coins in order, from the census at Christ's birth to Paul's appeal to Caesar, each beside its passage and a painting of the scene
- **Hands of History** — *whose hands held this?* Students see a coin and guess whose hands held it: a Roman soldier, a Temple priest, a widow, a merchant, a mother in Bethlehem, Paul of Tarsus or a Nabataean princess
- **Real or Replica?** — five rounds of genuine against fake (casting, die transfer, sand casting, false dies and a modern reproduction), with the clues experts use to tell them apart
- **Two posters** — *Faith and Reason* (Lemaître, Mendel, the Vatican Observatory and the Dead Sea Scrolls) and *The Weight of Thirty Pieces* (the Pilate Stone, the Tyrian shekel, the potter's field and the Caiaphas ossuary)

SUGGESTED APPROACHES BY GRADE

Where to begin with each age

PreK–2

- Real coins, held by real people, long ago
- Giving: the widow's two small coins
- Looking closely — big or tiny, face or no face?

LEAD WITH the Widow's Mite, Augustus (the journey to Bethlehem) and *Hands of History*.

BEFORE YOU GO pass around a coin from a pocket and ask *whose face is this?*

Grades 3–4

- Coins tell us who was in charge
- Matching each coin to its Bible story
- Real or fake: the clues of age and wear

LEAD WITH the Gospel Timeline, the Tribute Penny and *Real or Replica?*

BEFORE YOU GO read Matthew 22:15–22 and ask *how did Jesus escape the trap?*

Grades 5–6

- Roman rule in Judaea: emperors, client kings and prefects
- Image and inscription as claims of power
- How historians use coins as evidence

LEAD WITH Pilate, the Tribute Penny, the Shekel of Tyre and Aretas IV.

BEFORE YOU GO *if someone found one of our coins in two thousand years, what would it tell them?*

Grades 7–8

- Corroboration: Josephus, Suetonius and the Pilate Stone
- Authentication, and the habit of asking *is this authentic?*
- Faith and reason as partners in the search for truth

LEAD WITH Agrippa I, Claudius, Festus and both posters.

BEFORE YOU GO *what would it take to convince you an ancient coin is real?*

A NOTE FOR THE YOUNGEST

Several of these stories are violent: Herod the Great's order in Bethlehem, John the Baptist's death, the execution of James. For PreK–4, tell Herod the Great's coin as the story of the flight into Egypt, and let the Widow's Mite, the Tribute Penny and Augustus carry the visit.

AFTER THE VISIT

Quick discussion

- Which coin surprised you most, and why?
- Which person who held one of these coins would you most like to have met?
- Jesus said, give back to God what is God's. What belongs to God?

SIMPLE EXTENSIONS

Take it further

- Design a coin for your school: whose image, whose inscription?
- Write the journey of one coin from hand to hand
- Make a coin rubbing, and look for what makes each coin different

DURING THE VISIT

Guided questions, coin by coin

Ask one, wait, and let students look before anyone answers — in front of the case or with the coin on screen.

CASE 6 · THE WORLD OF JESUS



Augustus Caesar

BRONZE AS · 5–4 BC · LUKE 2:1

- Augustus never visited Judaea, yet his census sent Mary and Joseph to Bethlehem. How can an order given far away change ordinary lives?



Aretas IV

BRONZE PRUTAH · 9 BC–40 AD · MARK 6:17–18

- This king appears in the stories of John the Baptist and of Paul's escape from Damascus. How can one coin connect three stories?



Herod the Great

BRONZE PRUTAH · 40–4 BC · MATTHEW 2:13

- This king's coins carry no human face. Why not? What did he put on them instead?

CASE 7 · MINISTRY AND PASSION



The Widow's Mite

BRONZE LEPTON · MARK 12:41–44

- Why are two of these coins displayed, not one?
- How can the smallest coin be the biggest gift?



Shekel of Tyre REPLICA

SILVER SHEKEL · 1 BC–1 AD · MATTHEW 26:15

- The only coin the Temple accepted carried the image of a pagan god. Why accept it? And what does it mean that it became the price of betrayal?



Herod Antipas REPLICA

BRONZE PRUTAH · 4 BC–39 AD · LUKE 23:9

- Jesus spoke to Pilate, to the High Priest and to his accusers, but gave Antipas not one word. Why might silence be an answer?



The Tribute Penny REPLICA

SILVER DENARIUS OF TIBERIUS · MATTHEW 22:21

- Whose image is this? And whose inscription?
- The reverse reads PONTIF MAXIM, *High Priest*. Why would that offend a faithful Jew?



Pontius Pilate

BRONZE PRUTAH · 29/30 AD · MATTHEW 27:24

- Minted in the year of the Passion, by the man who sentenced Jesus. What changes when you know that?
- Some scholars doubted Pilate existed until 1961. What had this coin been all along?

CASE 8 · THE EARLY CHURCH



Herod Agrippa I

BRONZE PRUTAH · 41–44 AD · ACTS 12:2–3

- Acts and the historian Josephus describe Agrippa's death in almost identical terms. Why does an outside witness matter?



Porcius Festus

BRONZE PRUTAH · 59–62 AD · ACTS 25:12

- Paul appealed to Caesar as a Roman citizen. What is a right, and why did this one matter?



Emperor Claudius

BRONZE AS · 41–54 AD · ACTS 18:2

- Claudius drove Aquila and Priscilla out of Rome, and they met Paul in Corinth. How did a hard decree end up helping the early Church?

AT HANDS OF HISTORY

- Whose hands held this coin? What did they buy with it?
- The coins survived and the hands did not. Who would you most like to have met?

AT REAL OR REPLICA?

- Which one is genuine? What clue gave the fake away?
- A genuine widow's mite is crude and off-center. Why should a *perfect* one make you suspicious?

SUBJECT CONNECTIONS

One exhibition, six subjects

Religion

Render unto Caesar and the image of God; the widow's gift; thirty pieces of silver; Jesus' silence before Antipas; the *Faith and Reason* poster.

Social Studies

How Rome ruled Judaea through emperors, client kings, prefects and procurators; Roman citizenship and Paul's appeal; Josephus and Suetonius.

Math

Timelines across BC and AD; the length of a reign; weight in grams (Pilate's prutah, 1.79 g); a half-shekel Temple tax — what would thirty shekels pay?

Art

What rulers put on coins: Tiberius' face, Melqart, Pilate's ladle and ears of grain — and Herod's coins, with no human image at all.

ELA

Point of view in *Hands of History*: the story of a coin told by the hand that held it. The trap question, and Jesus' answer with a question of his own.

Science

Bronze and silver; why the Tyrian shekel's pure silver mattered; struck and cast coins; patina, wear and the clues experts read in *Real or Replica?*

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS

What students often think

MISCONCEPTION

"A replica is a fake."

IN THE EXHIBITION

Three coins here are museum-quality replicas, labeled as such. A fake is made to deceive; a replica is honest about what it is.

MISCONCEPTION

"A real ancient coin looks perfect."

IN THE EXHIBITION

A genuine lepton was struck crudely and off-center. If a lepton looks perfect, be suspicious: the imperfection is the proof.

MISCONCEPTION

"The coins prove the Gospel."

IN THE EXHIBITION

Faith is not proved by archaeology, as the exhibition says plainly. The coins prove that the world the Gospels describe was a real world.

ASSESSMENT IDEAS

- **Exit ticket:** *name one coin, the Bible story it belongs to and the person who held it*
- **Think-pair-share:** *why does it matter that a coin can be tested in a way a text cannot?*
- **Quick write:** *what does the Widow's Mite teach about giving?*

LARGER PROJECTS

- A museum label for one coin: date, ruler, verse and why it matters
- A timeline of all eleven coins, placed across BC and AD
- A *Real or Replica?* talk explaining one way fakes are made

PLANNING YOUR LESSONS

Lesson plans and differentiated handouts

Full lesson plans are written for PreK–K, Grades 1–2 and Grades 3–4, and for Grades 5–8 in four subjects: Religion (*Whose Image Is This?*, on the Tribute Penny), Social Studies, Math and Art. Each comes with three student handouts — **Green** (more support), **Yellow** (grade level) and **Red** (go deeper) — and students choose their own. All three levels read the same coin and the same passage, so the class can talk together afterward whatever each student chose. *Using the Differentiated Student Handouts* explains the system in two pages; the *Family Resource Guide* goes home with ideas for parents.

For a virtual visit, the coins, the Gospel Timeline, *Hands of History*, *Real or Replica?* and both posters are online at minimuseumproject.org/exhibitions/in-their-hands, and every plan and handout is at minimuseumproject.org/exhibitions/in-their-hands/resources. Even ten minutes with one coin and one good question is a visit worth making.